TECHNISCHE UNIVERSITÄT DARMSTADT

Guideline for User Interviews

User interviews help you understand, test, and improve your project ideas. They are a key part of human-centered design. This is not a survey, it's a conversation. Most of the time, especially in the early stage of your product, you're there to listen, not to pitch!

Preparation

Define your goal: What do you want to learn?

- Understand the problem? (→ create/adjust persona)
- Test your idea? (→ concept feedback)
- Improve your prototype or MLP? (→ usability)

Select interview partners

- Choose real users or people close to the problem (not friends unless they fit)
- Think about diversity: age, background, role, experience
- Ask politely via email/in person, explain the project and time needed
- Interview at least 3 people per phase/goal to spot patterns

What to bring (depends on the phase/goal)

- Notepad, pen, interview questions
- Consent sheet (you can also get this vocally)
- Voice recorder/phone → If you can't take notes
- Sketches/paper prototype → Testing early ideas
- Clickable mockup on tablet/laptop→ Prototype testing

Interview Guide

Use a mix of question types:

- Warm-up: Tell me about your day / work / typical situation.
- Problem-focused: What's hard about…? / How do you deal with…?
- Idea feedback: What's your first reaction to this idea/sketch?
- Prototype testing: Try it out, what would you do first? What's confusing?
- Reflective: Would this help you? Why or why not?

Interview Best Practices

- Be respectful, curious, and open-minded
- Be neutral, don't try to sell your idea
- Create a safe space: you're not judging them, and they're not judging you
- Start with thank you and context: Thanks for your time. We're working on a student project to help with [topic]. Your experience can really help us improve it. Would it be okay if we asked you a few questions?
- Ask for consent: Is it okay if we take notes / record this interview for our project? Only the team will see it. (If you record, get clear verbal or written consent.)
- Use open-ended questions
    - Don't ask: Do you like this?
    - Ask: What do you think this is for/Please walk me through what you'd do?
- Let them finish talking, silence is okay!
- Ask follow-ups like:
    - Can you give an example?
    - Why was that hard for you?
    - How did that make you feel?

After the Interview

- Right after: Write down what stood out, any quotes, what surprised you
- Group findings across interviews:
    - What problems were common?
    - What reactions were strong?
    - What do users actually want or need?

Phase: Understanding Users & Their Needs

Goal

Build empathy/compassion, create or adjust your persona, update problem definition

- When: Before you decide on a solution
- What to ask: Open, exploratory questions
- How many users: 3–5 if possible, diverse in age/background if relevant

Example questions:

- What can you tell me about a typical day?
- What are some challenges you face in [the area your project focuses on]?
- What do you do when that happens?
- How does that make you feel?
- Have you ever tried to solve this problem? How?

Phase: Testing the Project Idea

Goal

Validate your assumptions and check if your idea fits real needs, adjust your concept/feature list

- When: After brainstorming & selecting an idea
- What to ask: Concrete questions about your concept
- How: Show sketches, explain the main idea in 1–2 minutes

Example questions:

- We're thinking about a solution that [brief explanation].
  What's your first impression?
- Do you think this could be helpful? Why or why not?
- Would this fit into your daily life?
- Is anything missing or unclear?
- Who else might need this?

Phase: Feedback on Prototype or MLP

Goal

Improve your design based on real reactions, clear feedback for improvement, revised prototype

- When: After building a first prototype or MLP
- What to ask: Specific usability and value questions
- How: Let users interact with it (paper prototype, mockup, app)

Example questions:

- What do you think this is for?
- Try to use it. What would you click first?
- Was anything confusing?
- What did you like or dislike?
- Would you use this regularly? Why or why not?
- How could this be even better for you?

→ Use the *think aloud method*: Ask users to speak their thoughts as they try it

→ Don't explain too much, see if it's intuitive